



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 26

MISSISSIPPI

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Mississippi's family courts and child-welfare system.

34

MISSISSIPPI FAMILIES ON
RECORD · 57 CHILDREN
IMPACTED · 17 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 7, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

18 OF 82

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MISSISSIPPI AT A GLANCE.

Across 34 Mississippi families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 57 34 of 34 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$248,929 median across 10 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 17 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 50.0% 35.3% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 34	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.7	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 34 of 34	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 18

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Mississippi families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MISSISSIPPI FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	25	\$10,000	\$40,310	\$1,007,758
Lost Wages	14	\$5,500	\$40,714	\$570,001
Other Court Fees	8	\$0	\$2,663	\$21,301
Therapy / Evaluations	15	\$1,000	\$2,692	\$40,375
Reunification Services	9	\$0	\$411	\$3,701
GAL Fees	16	\$1,750	\$5,900	\$94,401
Asset Loss	12	\$78,000	\$121,333	\$1,456,001
Median Family Burden (10 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$248,929	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		17	1.4 yrs
Mean months lost		22	1.8 yrs
Total across all families		442	36.8 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · MISSISSIPPI

Most families documenting in Mississippi are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		20	59%
Not provided		6	18%
Case closed: within last 2 years		4	12%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		2	6%
Active case: progress being made		1	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		14	41%
Family Court Only		9	26%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		8	24%
Unknown		3	9%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		11	32%
Less than 6 months		8	24%
5 – 10 years		5	15%
3 – 5 years		3	9%
6 months – 1 year		2	6%

CUSTODY STATUS

Children in Foster Care		11	32%
Visitation Only		7	21%
Full Custody		7	21%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		6	18%
50/50 Joint		2	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Harrison		4	12%
Lamar		3	9%
Forrest		2	6%
Jackson		2	6%
Rankin		2	6%
Lowndes		1	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		10	29%
High Conflict Divorce		5	15%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		5	15%
Other: (Short answer)		4	12%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		2	6%

04 PARENT VOICES — MISSISSIPPI

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Mississippi comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

!!

This system is what creates drug users and abusers. This system that is sworn to protect the innocent and vulnerable children do nothing but destroy families and lives or hundreds if not thousands. All they see when they see kids is a dollar sign.

— MICHELLE

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Emboldened an abuser to continue to abuse & oppress a mother & children after physical exodus. I've been disillusioned & no longer trust the system to help victims of abuse or represent the best interest of the children. I've learned the system is for abusers, not for their [...]

— MISSISSIPPI PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM MISSISSIPPI

Judge stated I would receive more financially because abuse was proven; opposite happened AND house given to husband

— JANICE

Taken my sons away (kidnapped/trafficked) Given them to abusers making them suicidal and not trusting anyone for help/hopeless and destroyed their physical and mental health

— DANA

Family court didn't just make a ruling—it tore my children from their mother against their will and silenced their voices in the process. What was supposed to protect them broke their trust in the very system meant to help, and we're still working to heal from that damage.

— RAMONA

My kids have lost faith in a system that was supposed to get help for their dad. GAL has sided with the abuser...their dad....we have proof. The kids have been humiliated by GAL going to school to pull them from class to talk to them...when she privately met with them multiple [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



my family has been placed into crisis due to their actions. We have been financially hurt and emotionally abused due to their negligence and false claims.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system I was (finally) brave enough to contact, the one I held in such high esteem for protection and “doing what’s right,” has compounded the harm I was seeking safety from and punished me for trying to protect my children and myself.

— ALEX

It has taken out souls we can’t breathe it’s like there drowning and I can’t help

— ASHLEY JEAN

Me and my husband can't eat or sleep

— BENITEZ

Stripped a child from a Loving family. We are still stalked harassed bulluef. One sister not allowed to be apart of her sister life. Full custody of 1 child but not allowed to see the other

— KRISTEN

I followed the rules, told the truth, and still lost my son to a system that protects power over people

— ALEXIS

Separated a child from blood family, for rich family.

— MARIE

It has caused me so much emotional stress. I can't eat or sleep. I'm lucky to have a very understanding boss or I probably would have lost my job

— CHARLOTTE

I am traumatized by the court system and afraid to return into the court room. I am now taking anti- anxiety medications and would prefer to just disappear

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



It's bullshit that they can literally follow someone everywhere they go and take videos of them without their knowledge and turn it in for Court

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system turned an unsubstantiated investigation into court orders, contempt, arrest, and foster care without basic due process, and it has taken months of normal family life from us and our children. We have complied, stayed present, and fought to be heard, while our [...]

— WILLIAM

They took everything from me I would have given willingly to keep my girls. My Name, My Career, My Education, My Church, My Community, My Possessions, My Friends, My Family.

— LACY

The system has not only ripped my family apart it has taken away valuable time with my sons. it is placed a huge burden on my immediate family and has built a wall between my mother and sister and me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took our daughter when she was 4 days old..

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

my child was taken for missing 5 unexcused absences at the height of the COVID 19 pandemic, my son is not the same boy. they knew they were wrong and they didn't care.

— ANTHONY

The family court took an active, loving relationship away from me and my children, turning everyday life together into absence and loss. That separation has caused deep, lasting harm by breaking the bond that gave my children security and gave us our family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

22 Mississippi parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 22 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MISSISSIPPI

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Mississippi families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

This system is what creates drug users and abusers. This system that is sworn to protect the innocent and vulnerable children do nothing but destroy families and lives or hundreds if not thousands. All they see when they see kids is a dollar sign.

— MICHELLE

Judge stated I would receive more financially because abuse was proven; opposite happened AND house given to husband

— JANICE

Taken my sons away (kidnapped/trafficked) Given them to abusers making them suicidal and not trusting anyone for help/hopeless and destroyed their physical and mental health

— DANA

Family court didn't just make a ruling—it tore my children from their mother against their will and silenced their voices in the process. What was supposed to protect them broke their trust in the very system meant to help, and we're still working to heal from that damage.

— RAMONA

My kids have lost faith in a system that was supposed to get help for their dad. GAL has sided with the abuser...their dad....we have proof. The kids have been humiliated by GAL going to school to pull them from class to talk to them...when she privately met with them multiple times without parents present. Financial strain...which only affects kids more. The courts don't care how much time passes. These are precious years wasted with these boys living in a unsettled situation that could have easily been resolved on first court date.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Emboldened an abuser to continue to abuse & oppress a mother & children after physical exodus. I've been disillusioned & no longer trust the system to help victims of abuse or represent the best interest of the children. I've learned the system is for abusers, not for their victims trying to survive in peace. Perjury doesn't exist in family court. Evidence is not necessary for lies to be believed. It doesn't matter what you can prove. It matters most where the judge's bias is.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

my family has been placed into crisis due to their actions. We have been financially hurt and emotionally abused due to their negligence and false claims.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system I was (finally) brave enough to contact, the one I held in such high esteem for protection and “doing what’s right,” has compounded the harm I was seeking safety from and punished me for trying to protect my children and myself.

— ALEX

It has taken out souls we can’t breathe it’s like there drowning and I can’t help

— ASHLEY JEAN

Me and my husband can't eat or sleep

— BENITEZ

Stripped a child from a Loving family. We are still stalked harassed bulluef. One sister not allowed to be apart of her sister life. Full custody of 1 child but not allowed to see the other

— KRISTEN

I followed the rules, told the truth, and still lost my son to a system that protects power over people

— ALEXIS

Separated a child from blood family, for rich family.

— MARIE

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

It has caused me so much emotional stress. I can't eat or sleep. I'm lucky to have a very understanding boss or I probably would have lost my job

— CHARLOTTE

I am traumatized by the court system and afraid to return into the court room. I am now taking anti- anxiety medications and would prefer to just disappear

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It's bullshit that they can literally follow someone everywhere they go and take videos of them without their knowledge and turn it in for Court

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system turned an unsubstantiated investigation into court orders, contempt, arrest, and foster care without basic due process, and it has taken months of normal family life from us and our children. We have complied, stayed present, and fought to be heard, while our children have missed holidays, milestones, and everyday parenting time that can never be replaced.

— WILLIAM

They took everything from me I would have given willingly to keep my girls. My Name, My Career, My Education, My Church, My Community, My Possessions, My Friends, My Family.

— LACY

The system has not only ripped my family apart it has taken away valuable time with my sons. it is placed a huge burden on my immediate family and has built a wall between my mother and sister and me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took our daughter when she was 4 days old..

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

my child was taken for missing 5 unexcused absences at the height of the COVID 19 pandemic, my son is not the same boy. they knew they were wrong and they didn't care.

— ANTHONY

The family court took an active, loving relationship away from me and my children, turning everyday life together into absence and loss. That separation has caused deep, lasting harm by breaking the bond that gave my children security and gave us our family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

22 full approved Mississippi comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Mississippi report comes from Mississippi respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Mississippi — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 34 Mississippi families reporting here are not the universe of Mississippi families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

STANDWITHMEG.COM | COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE.